

Aijia Zhang

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Research Interests

Empirical Corporate Finance, Corporate Governance, Foreign Institutional Investors, and Chinese Capital Markets.

Education

University of Glasgow <i>PhD in Finance Programme</i> Expected Graduation: December 2026	10/2022–Present <i>Glasgow, UK</i>
University of Glasgow <i>Master of Science in Management with International Finance with Distinction</i>	01/2021–03/2022 <i>Glasgow, UK</i>
Beijing Normal - Hong Kong Baptist University (BNBU) <i>Bachelor of Business Administration (Honours) in Applied Economics</i>	09/2016–06/2020 <i>Zhuhai, China</i>

Working Papers (selected presentations by co-author denoted by *)

- **Foreign Institutional Investors' Site Visits and Tunnelling** [SSRN] (*Job Market Paper*)
This study investigates how foreign institutional investors' (FIIs) site visits affect tunnelling through inter-corporate loans. Using all Chinese firms listed on the Shenzhen Stock Exchange from 2012 to 2022, I find that FIIs' site visits significantly curb tunnelling across three different measures of site visits. Propensity score matching and multi-period difference-in-difference analysis show that this relation is causal. The effect is more pronounced when FIIs hold larger stakes, indicating that greater ownership enhances the effectiveness of their more frequent and intensive site visits in curbing tunnelling. The curbing effect of FIIs' site visits on tunnelling is more significant than that of site visits by other institutional investors, including Hong Kong, Macao, and Taiwan (HMT), Sino-foreign, and mainland institutional investors. Finally, I show that FIIs play a more effective monitoring role when they visit alongside other types of institutional investors rather than exclusively with other FIIs, suggesting that the complementary expertise within a heterogeneous group of visitors strengthens monitoring. The study contributes to the literature on tunnelling problems and the disciplining role of FIIs in weak institutional environments.
 - Selected Presentations: University of Strathclyde (Scheduled 2026), FMA (2025), FMA Europe (2025), EFMA (2025), CEA (2025)
- **Foreign Institutional Investors and Underperforming CEOs: Evidence from Chinese Listed Firms** [SSRN] (*with Martin Strieborny*)
Using a sample of Chinese listed firms from 2009 to 2023, we show that foreign institutional shareholdings raise CEO turnover-performance sensitivity, and we identify two transmission channels driving this result: the quality of corporate governance and stock price informativeness. We address endogeneity concerns with a staggered difference-in-differences analysis exploiting the exogenous shock to foreign institutional ownership from the introduction of the Shanghai/Shenzhen–Hong Kong Stock Connect Programme.
 - Selected Presentations: FMA (2026), Humboldt University* (2025)
- **Investor–Firm Interactions and Corporate Innovation: Evidence from China** [SSRN]
Using 6,115 Chinese A-share listed firms over 2010–2023, this paper shows that investor–firm interactions on regulated online platforms are positively associated with subsequent innovation, measured by granted invention patents, with financial constraints acting as a partial mediating channel. The effect is stronger when information asymmetry is higher and institutional monitoring is weaker, suggesting that such platforms promote innovation by reducing information asymmetry between retail investors and firm management.

- Selected Presentations: FMA (2026)

Work in Progress

Pay Restriction and Corporate Policies: Evidence from State-Owned Listed Firms (*with Mengqian Chen*)

Conferences and Seminars (selected presentations by co-author denoted by *)

2026:

University of Strathclyde Accounting & Finance Seminar (*scheduled*)
 Financial Management Association (FMA) Annual Conference
 Asian Finance Association (AsianFA) Annual Conference (*accepted*)
 European Financial Management Association (EFMA) Annual Conference (*accepted*)

2025:

Humboldt University of Berlin Seminar*
 Financial Management Association (FMA) Annual Conference
 Financial Management Association (FMA) European Conference
 European Financial Management Association (EFMA) Annual Conference
 Chinese Economic Association (CEA) Annual Conference

Discussions

2026: FMA (Tampa), AsianFA (Seoul), EFMA (Kristiansand)

2025: FMA (Vancouver), FMA Europe (Limassol), EFMA (Athens)

Academic Services

University of Glasgow

01/2025–Present

Co-organisier, Internal Seminars for Finance PhDs

Glasgow, UK

- Organising a seminar series in which finance PhD students present their research and receive feedback, and inviting faculty members to discuss their own papers or share job market insights.

University of Glasgow

10/2023–Present

Graduate Teaching Assistant (GTA)

- Course: ACCFIN5203 Foundations of International Corporate Finance (postgraduate course).
Explaining key concepts in international corporate finance, including agency conflicts, mergers and acquisitions, and the time value of money. Providing guidance on effectively reading and interpreting corporate finance literature.
- Course: ACCFIN4070 Corporate Finance (undergraduate course).
Leading tutorials on core corporate finance topics, including the valuation, capital structure, and dividend policy. Working through applied problems with students and providing written feedback on assessed work.

Awards, Grants, and Certificates

Employability Funding, Adam Smith Business School with multiple awards (PhD) 2025

Employability Funding, Adam Smith Business School with multiple awards (PhD) 2024

CFA Level I Pass 2020

Academic Excellence Scholarship, First Class (Undergraduate) 2019/2020

Academic Excellence Scholarship, Second Class (Undergraduate) 2018/2019

Skills

Software: Python, Matlab, Stata, EViews, SPSS, LaTeX and Microsoft-based software

Databases: CSMAR (China Stock Market & Accounting Research), CNRDS (Chinese Research Data Services), Wind, Qichacha, Bloomberg, BoardEx

Languages: Chinese (Native), English (Fluent), Korean (Intermediate)

References

Dr Martin Strieborny (Main Supervisor)

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Professor Patrick Verwijmeren (Co-supervisor)

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